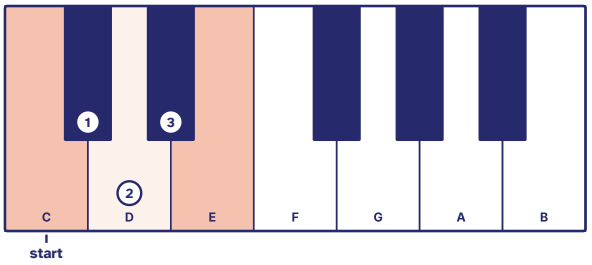
PART I · PITCH · 8

Major, minor and perfect

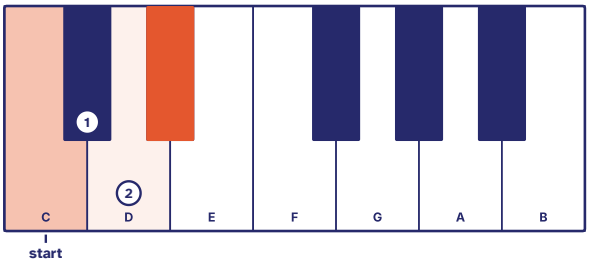
C to E and C to E♭ are both 3rds: three notes each. But they sound different, bright and dark. To tell them apart, **count the keys in between**, black and white: the keys you do not play.

THE SECRET

3 keys between: a major 3rd. 2 keys between: a minor 3rd.



C to **E**: 3 keys between. A **major** 3rd: bright.



C to **E♭**: 2 keys between, one fewer. A **minor** 3rd: dark.

One key fewer between: a major 3rd becomes minor

THE RULE

Count the notes for the number (a 3rd). Count the keys in between for the size (major or minor): black and white, not the two you play.

Why count the keys in between? Because the size is what you hear: one key more or less turns bright into dark, or makes a 5th sound hollow and strange.

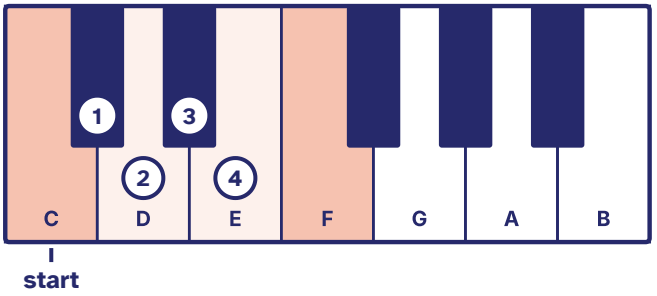
NUMBER	KEYS BETWEEN: MINOR	MAJOR OR PERFECT
3rd	2 (minor)	3 (major)
4th		4 (perfect)
5th		6 (perfect)
6th	7 (minor)	8 (major)
octave		11 (perfect)

3rds and 6ths come in two sizes: **major** and **minor**.

4ths, 5ths and octaves have one main size, called **perfect**. They are never major or minor.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

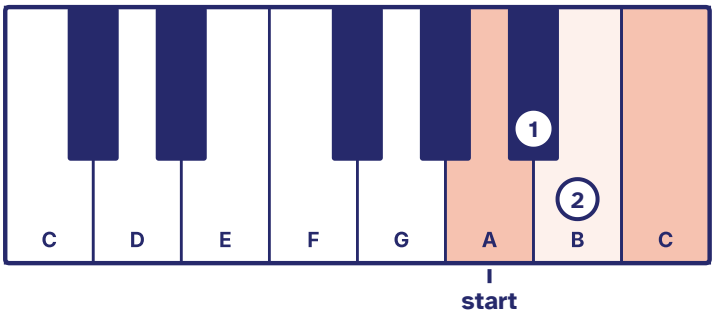
A perfect 4th



C to **F**: four notes, a 4th, with **4 keys between**: a **perfect 4th**.

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor 3rd? A up to C

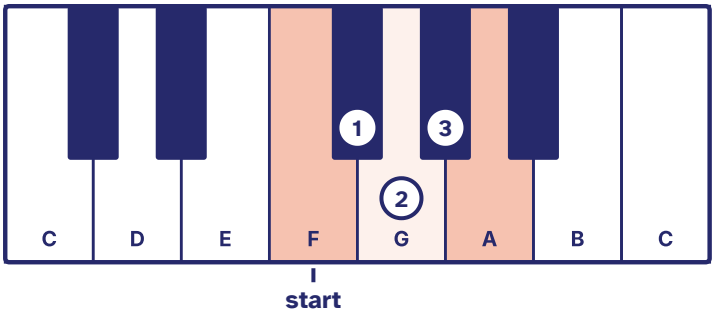


1. **Count the notes:** A B C, three letters, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **A major 3rd has 3 between.** How many here?

A to C has **2 keys between** (B♭ and B): one fewer than major, a **minor 3rd**. Dark, like C to E♭.

EXAMPLE 2

Name F up to A



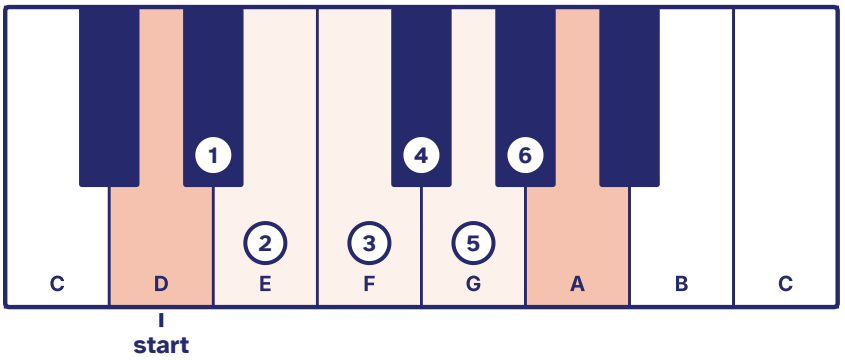
1. **Count the notes:** F G A is 3, so it is a 3rd.
2. **Count the keys in between:** they are numbered.
3. **3 between, or 2?**

F to A has 3 keys between: a **major 3rd**, the same size as C to E.

PART I · PITCH · 8 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Name D up to A
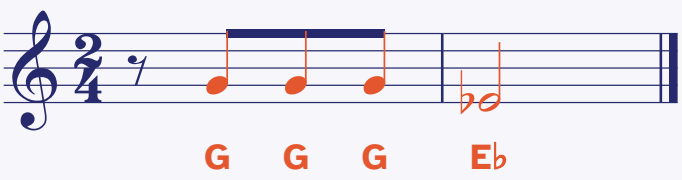


1. **The number:** D E F G A, five notes, a 5th.
2. **The size:** count the keys in between: the numbered keys.
3. **A 5th with 6 between** is its main size. What is that called?

D up to A is a **perfect 5th**: 6 keys between.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Symphony No. 5



Da-da-da-DUM: G down to E♭ is three notes, a 3rd, with 3 keys between (F♯, F, E): a **major 3rd**. Counting down works the same way.

Try it. Count the keys between G and E♭ on the keyboard.

THINK OF IT A major and a minor 3rd are a smile and a frown: the same face, one small change at the corners.

TRAP

- × Counting white keys only: count every key between, black and white.
- × Calling a 4th or 5th “major”: they are perfect.
- × C–D♯ is a 2nd, C–E♭ a 3rd: the same keys, but the letters decide the number.

SEE ALSO

Counting intervals p. 42 · Chords and triads p. 110

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 8 · Online: Intervals (Major or minor 3rd)